this bolster, the corpse would be placed as if reclining on it.

From where our townspeople picked up this new fad of propping up a corpse on a chair, we had no clue, but from that day troubles began for our chair. (They had moved from floor-tickets to chair-tickets!)

When the "occasion" in that household was over, they left the chair in our front yard. The children of the house were scared even to look at the chair. We had the servant take it to the well and give it a good, hard scrub with hay, and wash it down with fifteen big buckets of water. Even after several days, no one had the guts to sit on it. We didn't know how to bring it back into use.

Fortuitously, a guest visited our house one day. We had the chair brought for him. "Don't bother, I'll sit here," he said, and went towards the cloth-mat. We were afraid that he would sit on the floor. The whole family persuaded him to sit on the chair. As soon as he sat down, my little brother and sister fled to the garden in the backyard. Now and then, they peeped in to see what happened to the man on the chair.

The next day a local elder dropped by and chose to sit on the chair on his own, bringing us even more relief. ("He's rehearsing on the chair now itself," whispered Pedanna in my ear!) This is how we "seasoned" the chair. First, the elders in the family sat on it. The children were still afraid. My little sister would beg my little brother, "Why don't you sit on it first, da?" He would retort instantly, "Why don't you sit and see?"

Suganthi, from the neighbouring street, came by and put her baby brother on the chair. It was only from then on that the children of our house sat on the chair without fear.

Again, one night someone died and they took away the chair. This happened ever so often. We sent away the chair with sadness. The mourners who came interpreted our sadness differently. They assumed that we too were mourning for the dead.

We were irritated that our sleep was being thus disturbed. Akka remarked one day, "God knows why these wretched people have to go and die at such unearthly hours!" Anna said **exasperatedly**, "Good chair we made. For the corpses of our village to sit on. Tchai!"

"All because the chair was ordered at an inauspicious time," said our aunt.

Pedanna finally thought of an idea. We kept it to the two of us.

Amma sent me on an errand to Maamanaar's house one day. When I entered his house, there he was, sitting in **splendour** on his chair and popping betel leaves into his mouth. It was an interesting pastime in itself to see him prepare and chew the betel leaves. Carefully, with utmost gentleness so as not to injure it, he would open his beloved betel box. A span wide, an elbow long, and four fingers high, he would clean and burnish it every day till it shone like gold. He would reverently take out his **paraphernalia**, as if taking out things from a pooja-box.



12th General_English_Unit_5_A_Prose.indd 146 07-12-2021 18:13:04